# Leadership Tool: After Action Review

An After-Action Review (AAR) is a structured review process designed to analyze what happened during a project or activity, why it happened, and how it can be improved. This tool is essential for capturing lessons learned and promoting continuous improvement within an organization, department, or team. Originating in the U.S. Army, the AAR process has since been adopted by various sectors, including business, healthcare, and education, to enhance performance and outcomes. The AAR process involves open and honest discussions that help teams understand their successes and challenges, fostering a culture of learning and accountability.

As an effective leader, it is important to continue to do AAR each time a project is completed. Primarily, AARs focus on learning and improvement, allowing teams to identify what worked well and what didn't, and how these insights can inform future actions. They also promote accountability by helping team members understand their contributions and areas for growth. Additionally, AARs strengthen team cohesion by encouraging open communication and collaboration, creating a shared understanding of the project's outcomes. Finally, the insights gained from AARs are invaluable for future planning, as they provide a clear roadmap for applying lessons learned to subsequent projects and activities. By systematically incorporating AARs into their workflow, effective leaders can significantly boost their teams' effectiveness and adaptability.

## Step-by-Step Guide for Conducting an After-Action Review (AAR)

The following is a step-by-step guide for leaders to utilize when facilitating an AAR. Included are the steps to follow, action items needing completion in each step, best-practices or tips to ensure AAR success, questions the leader can ask to help facilitate the AAR, and an example of each action item. Leaders can utilize this resource as a guide to execute an AAR with confidence and success.

### 1. Preparation

***Define Objectives***

- **Action**: Clarify the purpose and objectives of the AAR.
- **Tip**: Align objectives with organizational goals and specific outcomes of the reviewed activity.
- **Questions**:
    - What was the objective of the project/activity?
    - Were the objectives clear and achievable? Why or why not?

    - What were the key expectations and deliverables?
- **Example**: Before reviewing a product launch, clarify that the objective is to improve future launches by identifying what worked and what didn't.

***Gather Relevant Data***

- **Action**: Collect data, documents, and feedback related to the activity.
- **Tip**: Use surveys, interviews, and performance metrics to gather comprehensive information.
- **Questions**:
    - What actually happened during the project/activity?
    - Were the project objectives met? If not, why?
    - What were the key successes?
    - What were the main challenges or obstacles encountered?
- **Example**: For a marketing campaign, gather metrics on engagement, sales data, and feedback from the marketing team.

## 2. Setting the Stage

***Select a Facilitator***

- **Action**: Choose a skilled facilitator to guide the discussion.
- **Tip**: The facilitator should be skilled in moderating discussions and encouraging participation.

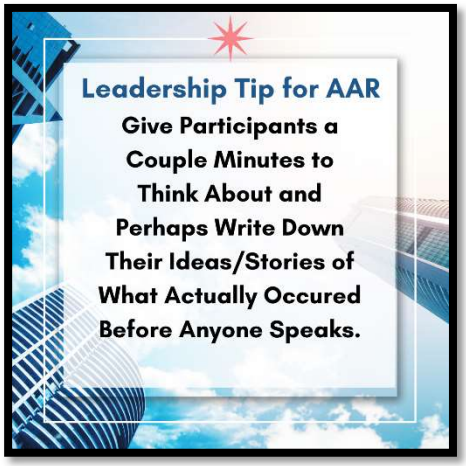
***Create a Safe Environment***

- **Action**: Ensure a non-judgmental, open atmosphere where participants feel safe to share their perspectives.
- **Tip**: Emphasize that the goal is learning and improvement, not assigning blame.
- **Example**: Begin the session by reiterating that all feedback is valuable and the focus is on improvement.

## 3. Conducting the Review

***Review Objectives and Agenda***

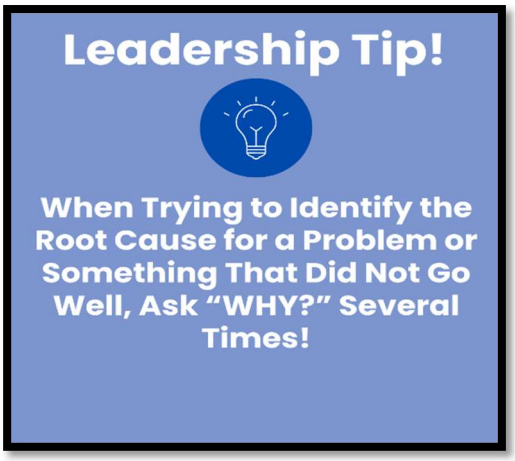
- **Action**: Start by reiterating the objectives and agenda of the AAR.
- **Tip**: Keep the session focused and structured to cover all relevant points.
- **Example**: Outline the session's flow, including discussing what happened, why it happened, and lessons learned.




***Discuss What Happened***

- **Action**: Ask participants to describe what happened during the activity.
- **Tip**: Use a timeline or sequence of events to guide the discussion.

- **Questions**:
    - How effectively did the team communicate throughout the project?
    - Were there any communication breakdowns or misunderstandings?
    - How well did team members collaborate and support each other?
- **Example**: In a construction project, create a timeline of key activities and ask team members to provide their perspectives on each phase.




***Analyze Why It Happened***

- **Action**: Encourage participants to discuss the reasons behind the outcomes.
- **Tip**: Use root cause analysis techniques to dig deeper into the underlying factors.
- **Questions**:
    - Was the planning process adequate and thorough?
    - Did the team follow the planned processes? If not, what changed?
    - Were the timelines and milestones realistic and met?

***Identify Lessons Learned***

- **Action**: Summarize the key takeaways and lessons learned from the discussion.
- **Tip**: Categorize lessons into strengths to sustain and weaknesses to improve.
- **Questions**:
    - What worked well that we should continue doing in future projects?
    - What didn't work well and why?
    - What specific improvements can be made for future projects?
- **Example**: In a software development project, note that daily stand-ups improved communication, but documentation practices needed improvement.

## 4. Action Planning

***Develop Recommendations***

- **Action**: Formulate actionable recommendations based on the lessons learned.
- **Tip**: Ensure recommendations are specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound (SMART).
- **Example**: Recommend implementing weekly check-ins to improve team alignment on future projects.

***Assign Responsibilities***

- **Action**: Assign clear responsibilities for implementing the recommendations.
- **Tip**: Use a RACI matrix (Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed) to clarify roles.
- **Example**: Assign the project manager to be responsible for scheduling and conducting weekly check-ins.

***Set Timelines***

- **Action**: Establish timelines for implementing the recommended actions.
- **Tip**: Create a follow-up schedule to review progress and make adjustments as needed.
- **Example**: Set a deadline for the implementation of weekly check-ins to be within the next month.

## 5. Documentation and Dissemination

***Document the AAR***

- **Action**: Record the key points, findings, and action plans from the AAR.
- **Tip**: Use a standardized template to ensure consistency and completeness.
- **Example**: Create a detailed report summarizing the discussion, key findings, and action items from the AAR session.

***Disseminate Findings***

- **Action**: Share the AAR report with all relevant stakeholders.
- **Tip**: Use multiple channels (e.g., email, intranet, meetings) to ensure broad dissemination.
- **Example**: Email the AAR report to the project team and stakeholders, and present the findings in the next team meeting.